

Two Red Books: Tolkien, Jung, and the Manufacture of Authority

A unified reading of three machine-generated structural analyses

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*Version 0.1 (August 2026). Register note: this paper is [A] **throughout** — an interpretive synthesis of three documents produced by the falsework.dev analysis pipelines (Claude Fable 5, August 2026): a Structural Profile of Tolkien’s Red Book of Westmarch, a Structural Profile of Jung’s Red Book (Liber Novus), and a Deep Synthesis comparing the two. The three source documents are themselves machine criticism: structured mappings, removal tests, and generative principles, with derived prose. This paper unifies them for a human reader. Nothing here is kernel-checked; where this paper adds an observation not present in the source documents, it says so.*

0. The coincidence

In the same decades of the early twentieth century, two men — apparently unaware of each other — each produced a *red book* that pretends to be older than it is.

J. R. R. Tolkien built the **Red Book of Westmarch**: the fictional manuscript from which *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* claim to be translated. It has no independent existence. It is instantiated entirely as apparatus — a prologue on Shire records, appendices, translator’s footnotes, and scenes of its own composition.

C. G. Jung built the **Liber Novus**: a large folio in red leather, hand-lettered in Gothic script with gold leaf and illuminated initials, into which he transcribed and interpreted his own visionary episodes over some fifteen years. It exists all too physically; it looks five centuries older than it is.

Jung’s Red Book was not published until 2009, decades after both men were dead. There is no evidence of transmission in either direction. Yet all three analyses converge on the finding that the two works run the *same structural machine* — and diverge on almost everything about how they run it.

1. The shared machine

The Deep Synthesis states the common mechanism as a single generative principle:

Replace the work's native chronology with a borrowed ordering system whose authority outranks the events it organizes.

Neither work asks its events to carry their own credibility. Tolkien's spine is a *stemma* — Bilbo's memoir passing to Frodo, to Sam, to the Thain's Book, to Findegil's copy of S.R. 1592 — in which time accumulates as textual sediment, layer on scribal layer. Jung's spine is the *dated diary entry* — "12 November 1913," night by night — set against the historyless non-time of the visions it frames; not sedimentation but spiral, the same figures returning at deeper registers.

Remove either spine and the same collapse occurs: Frodo's quest reverts to fantasy invention, Jung's visions to private effusion. With the spine in place, both are received as *evidence* — items arriving inside a system the reader already trusts. Both spines borrow that trust from the same ancestor: the pre-print codex tradition, the handmade book whose material labor vouches for its seriousness.

The synthesis documents the correspondence at six points, of which three carry the most weight:

1. **A non-narrative time system outranks event-time** — stemma or diary date; sediment or spiral.
2. **The frame is ground into the smallest units of prose.** Tolkien binds every proper noun ("Samwise" renders *Banazîr*): no name escapes the translation fiction. Jung binds every sentence's cadence: archaic-visionary diction against aphoristic commentary, the split running inside the syntax itself. In both books you cannot read a line without touching the frame.
3. **Each work plants one module that turns the apparatus's rules against it.** Tolkien preserves Bilbo's lying first account of the Ring inside the machinery of authentication — the archive documenting its own unreliability. Jung's *Septem Sermones ad Mortuos* abandons the vision-plus-commentary bilayer for fused catechism, dissolving the very frame that had domesticated everything before it.

And both structures rest on a bottom that is deliberately not there. Tolkien's "Translations from the Elvish" open a regress of sources with no visible floor; Jung's Elijah and Izdubar stand in a static mythic present with no *behind* at all. Infinite regress and timeless presence are two solutions to the same problem: what does the borrowed clock rest on? Answer: nothing the reader is permitted to reach.

2. The Tolkien machine: authenticate by omission

The Structural Profile of the Red Book of Westmarch identifies its core mechanism:

The work generates a nonexistent original by fabricating the complete apparatus of its recovery — density of transmission machinery substitutes for the existence of the source.

The profile's sharpest finding is the **amputated recovery link**. Tolkien documents every internal link of transmission with forensic care — who wrote each stratum, which copy contains what, which scribe annotated where — and then omits, entirely, how the codex reached the modern "editor." The chain terminates in a void. The governing rule, as the profile puts it: *every boundary is documented except the last one*. Exhaustive documentation everywhere else is precisely what makes the single undocumented link read as structure rather than oversight. The constraint is stated exactly: producing the original would make the frame falsifiable, so authentication depends on verification being *permanently deferred one stratum beyond reach*.

The profile also surfaces a mechanism it judges novel — **extradiegetic absorption**: real facts about the work's production are converted into events inside the fiction's transmission history. When Tolkien revised the riddle-game chapter between the 1937 and 1951 editions of *The Hobbit*, he did not erase the discrepancy; he recorded the first version as "Bilbo's lie," corrected in later recensions. A bug became patina, because the apparatus had already built the category (manuscript variance) to receive it. Real production history is *concealed by being metabolized into fictional production history*.

The profile names the competency this trains — **stemmatic perception**, tracking a text and its purported carrier simultaneously — and anchors the mechanism historically: Macpherson's *Ossian* ran the identical operation and collapsed at exactly the joint Tolkien armors, when Samuel Johnson demanded the Gaelic manuscripts.

3. The Jung machine: authenticate by exposure

The Structural Profile of the Liber Novus identifies its core mechanism:

Private timestamped experience becomes doctrine by re-inscribing it, plus a later interpretive stratum, inside a facsimile of a form that historically conferred scriptural authority — with the seams of that conversion left visible.

The deepest load-bearing stratum is **two-register stratification with dated anchoring**: nearly every chapter pairs a dated first-person vision (transcribed from the *Black Books* journals) with a retrospective sermonic commentary written months or years later, the two registers held adjacent on the same page. The dates make the gap between experience and interpretation a *measurable fact* rather than a rhetorical gesture.

And this yields the profile's most elegant finding: **the disguise depends structurally on the one element that betrays it**. Every register of the artifact — Gothic textura, rubrication, Luther-Bible syntax — enforces medieval timelessness. No scripture carries diary timestamps. Yet the dates cannot be removed: subtract them and the two registers collapse into one undifferentiated voice, and the medievalism degrades into mere pastiche. The work's authority-claim and its authenticity-claim are structurally incompatible, and the book holds both anyway.

Where Tolkien conceals his manufacture, Jung *displays* it: the visible transmission chain (Black Books → Draft → Corrected Draft → calligraphic copy), the parchment-to-paper shift, the variation in scribal hand across fifteen years, the text breaking off mid-sentence — and a 1959 epilogue that attempts retrospective closure and itself breaks off unfinished. The profile compresses this into a formula: *the work denies its ending, then denies the denial's repair*. Its structural implication is stated as an argument about authority itself: authority is conferred by form, and exposing the form does not dissolve it — “authority that survives the disclosure of its own construction is the only authority the work is willing to claim.”

The competency here is **stratigraphic reading**: tagging every passage by stratum — when was this written, and is it testifying or interpreting? — while holding the artifact's authority-claim and its fabrication evidence in a single act of attention.

4. The mirrored flaw

This section is this paper's own observation; it appears in neither profile, though it is implicit in the synthesis.

Run side by side, the two profiles reveal a symmetry neither could see alone: **both authentication machines depend on a deliberate flaw, and the flaws point in opposite directions**.

Tolkien's flaw is a *withheld link* — the one undocumented boundary in an otherwise exhaustively documented chain. Jung's flaw is a *retained anachronism* — the one modern element in an otherwise exhaustively medieval artifact. Tolkien authenticates by omission; Jung authenticates by exposure. One machine hides its manufacture (extradiegetic absorption converts real revisions into fictional recensions); the other displays its manufacture as content (exposed production stratigraphy). The platform's kernel-engagement classifier registered the same axis independently: the Westmarch profile reads *Concealed*, the Liber Novus profile reads *Exposed*.

In both cases a perfect apparatus would fail. A Red Book whose recovery was narrated would be falsifiable; a Liber Novus without timestamps would be pastiche. The imperfection is the load-bearing part.

5. Where the machines cannot swap parts

The Deep Synthesis is at its strongest where it argues that these are *not* the same machine — that each would destroy the other:

Authorial dispersal versus authorial doubling. Tolkien's authority comes from removing the author: Bilbo hands to Frodo, Frodo to Sam, Sam to scribes, until no single voice owns the text. Jung's meaning comes from dividing an author who must remain present: the man who saw the visions and the man who interprets them are one person, split. Give Jung a Findegil — a later scribe annotating the visions — and the self-interrogation that *is* the book evaporates into editorial distance. Give Tolkien a single fused author-interpreter and the documentary claim dies: the Red Book reads as confession, not transmitted history.

Apparatus that must never fail versus apparatus built to fail. Every Tolkien mechanism reasserts the frame; drop it anywhere and the work reverts to framed fiction. Jung's frame is built to break — the ending's power depends on the commentary being *unable* to process the Sermones. Transplant either logic into the other work and its climax flattens or its reality-claim collapses.

Process-fidelity versus content-remaking. Tolkien is faithful to the archive's *processes* (corruption, variance, transmission) while inventing all its contents. Jung mimics the archive's surface while violently remaking real inherited contents — Elijah, Salome, Gilgamesh-as-Izdubar, Siegfried killed on the page. A documentary machine only authenticates what it transmits unchanged; Jung's whole project is change. The two fidelities are mutually exclusive.

6. The principle, made portable

The synthesis abstracts the mechanism into a conditional transfer rule: *content organized by an apparatus the audience already credits — dates, stemmata, codex conventions — is received as evidence within that apparatus before it can be judged as invention.* The trick does not manufacture belief; it redirects belief that already exists.

Hence its portability is conditional. It transfers wherever a receiving culture possesses an ordering system of higher epistemic standing than fabricated narrative: the timestamp and degraded tape of found-footage cinema, the classification protocols of archival fiction, the mock-critical edition (*Pale Fire*), footnote fiction with exposed strata (*House of Leaves*), the co-present centuries of a Talmud page, the canonical hours of a liturgical cycle. It fails wherever no pre-authorized system exists, because the pattern cannot create the authority it borrows.

Both profiles supply the practitioner's version. From Tolkien: *document every seam except the last one; serialize authorship to give an object strata; absorb accumulated defects as transmission history rather than erasing them.* From Jung: *bind a provenance-marked primary stratum to a materially co-present interpretive stratum, house both in a faithful reproduction of an authority-bearing form, and refuse to hide the manufacture.*

7. Convergence without contact

The synthesis closes on the historical question the pairing forces. There is no evidence Tolkien and Jung knew each other's red books — Jung's was unpublished until 2009. But the analysis declines the romantic conclusion that two minds independently *invented* the same machine. Both works, it argues, draw on a common ancestor: the medieval manuscript tradition and its authority-transfer mechanics — which each man knew intimately, Tolkien as philologist, Jung through the codices his artifact imitates.

Two independent thefts from the same ancestor prove the mechanism belongs to the ancestor, not to either thief.

This verdict takes a side in a live scholarly question. Becca Tarnas's work on precisely this pair reads the parallels as archetypal convergence — evidence of a shared imaginal ground deeper than cultural transmission. The structural analyses land nearer the skeptic's position (shared origin, named ancestor), but with an important boundary: the pipelines analyzed *structural descriptions* of the two works. The visionary imagery on which the archetypal argument rests — the serpents, the descent landscapes, the painted

mandalas as vision-records — was outside their inputs. The structural verdict and the imaginal verdict answer different questions about the same pair, and the disagreement between them is better posed now than before.

8. Coda: on the instruments

This section is methodological and reflexive; it is about the three source documents rather than the two works.

The three documents were produced by two different pipelines — single-work Structural Profile and two-work Deep Synthesis — running independently. Their convergences were not coordinated: the synthesis’s “simulated incompleteness is what authenticates” and the Westmarch profile’s “suspension is load-bearing; a producible original would collapse the system” are the same discovery reached by different procedures. The Sermones-as-rupture reading recurs across both instruments. The concealed/exposed inversion appears in the synthesis as “loving forgery versus enacted anachronism” and re-emerges from the profiles’ own classifications.

The instruments also discriminated: the Westmarch profile detected nine canonical patterns (the work *is* nearly pure apparatus); the Liber Novus profile detected three, carried by fewer, deeper mechanisms. And they disagreed with themselves in at least one visible seam — the Liber Novus core classifies terminal incompleteness as *incidental* while its derived prose builds a thematic argument on it — which is the kind of divergence the core/wrapper distinction exists to keep visible rather than to smooth over.

All findings above remain [A]: structural readings produced by an instrument, unified by a human-directed synthesis, offered for calibration — ideally by readers who know these two red books better than any pipeline does.

Sources: falsework.dev Structural Profile, “Red Book of Westmarch” (Claude Fable 5, 2026-08-05); falsework.dev Structural Profile, “The Red Book (Liber Novus)” (Claude Fable 5, 2026-08-05); falsework.dev Deep Synthesis, Westmarch × Liber Novus (Claude Fable 5, 2026-08-05).